



BEFORE

After the Battle of Antietam, Lincoln was determined that McClellan's Army of the Potomac should pursue the Confederates into Virginia and seek to inflict defeat.

NORTHERN ADVANCE

General Lee's first thought after Antietam was also to **return to the offensive** (see [McClellan's folly](#)). Only the poor condition of his Army of Northern Virginia persuaded him **to rest and refit**. Meanwhile General McClellan, goaded by Lincoln, began reluctantly moving his army across the Potomac in late October 1862.

Incensed by his delays and lack of offensive spirit, as well as his insubordinate attitude toward the government, **Lincoln fired McClellan** on November 7, **appointing Major General Ambrose Burnside** in his place.

Major General Ambrose Burnside was not eager to command the Army of the Potomac, feeling that he lacked the competence required of an army commander. Even so, within days of taking charge he responded to Lincoln's demand for offensive action with a plan to seize Richmond, the Confederate capital. He would shift his force rapidly and abruptly to cross the Rappahannock River at Fredericksburg, driving toward the town before General Robert E. Lee could react. Lincoln favored fighting Lee's army rather than sidestepping it, but approved the plan.

Burnside's maneuver was finely executed. On November 15, his army of 120,000 men, organized into three "Grand Divisions," set off on a march that caught the Confederates by surprise. Within two days, Union troops were streaming into Falmouth, on the opposite bank of the Rappahannock from Fredericksburg. Nothing stood between Burnside and Richmond except the 400-ft (122-m) wide river. Bridging this obstacle had been given high priority in the planning, with urgent orders for pontoons to be sent, but these floating bridges were delayed.

Giving Lee time

Burnside would not send troops across fords because he anticipated that rising water levels might render them impassable, and he did not want to find himself with part of his army cut off on the other side of the river. So he waited for the pontoons, which gave Lee the